THE TEXAS HOMEBUYER'S

90-Day Mortgage Strategy Playbook

The unfiltered guide to buying a home in Texas — credit, cash, timelines, and exactly what to do each week before you apply.

★ INCLUDES FILLABLE BUDGET WORKSHEET
DTI calculator · Max payment · Down payment tracker

WHAT'S INSIDE:

- ✓ Week-by-week action items, not vague advice
- ✓ The real DTI formula your lender runs
- ✓ Documents you need before you apply
- ✓ What NOT to do in the 90 days before closing
- ✓ VA specifics: COE, funding fee, entitlement
- ✓ Texas option period & homestead exemption
- ✓ Closing cost breakdown for Texas
- ✓ City-specific notes: El Paso to Houston

PHASE 1
Days 1–30
Build Your Financial Foundation

PHASE 2
Days 31–60
Get Pre-Approved & Get Smart

PHASE 3
Days 61–90
Make Your Move

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This is not a brochure.

Most mortgage guides exist to explain loan programs. This one exists to tell you what to actually do — week by week — so you show up to your lender ready, qualified, and confident. The 90 days before you apply is when most buyers either set themselves up or quietly disqualify themselves. This playbook is about the former.

How to Use This Playbook

1. **Work through Phase 1 first.**
   Even if you think your credit and finances are solid, do the audit. Surprises at pre-approval are worse than surprises now.
2. **Fill out the Budget Worksheet (pages 5–6).**
   Real numbers beat estimates. Know your DTI before your lender calculates it for you.
3. **One phase at a time.**
   Don't skip to Phase 3. The work you do in Phases 1 and 2 determines what happens in Phase 3.
4. **Share this with your co-borrower.**
   If you're buying with a partner, both of you need to be on the same page — literally.
5. **Write in it.**
   This is a working document. Use the checklists, fill in the blanks, dog-ear the pages.

YOUR 90-DAY TIMELINE AT A GLANCE

PHASE 1 · Days 1–30	PHASE 2 · Days 31–60	PHASE 3 · Days 61–90
Credit · Income · Documents	Pre-Approval · Loan Selection · Offer	Inspection · Underwriting · Closing

Each phase builds on the last. Skipping steps doesn't save time — it creates problems at closing.

■ A WORD ON TIMING

The 90-day window assumes you're starting from scratch. If your credit is already clean, your documents are organized, and you know your DTI, you may be ready sooner. If you have collections, late payments, or a thin credit file, give yourself 120–180 days. Your broker will tell you the truth. Trust that more than the timeline.

Build Your Financial Foundation

This phase is about knowing exactly where you stand before anyone else does. Pull your numbers, fix what can be fixed, and assemble your document package. Do this right and pre-approval is a formality, not a surprise.

WEEK 1 Days 1–7

Credit Audit

- [ ] **Pull all 3 credit reports**

  Go to AnnualCreditReport.com — free and the only FTC-authorized site. This is your time to actually read what is reporting. Are there late payments? Open disputes with creditors? Accounts you don't recognize? Balances that look wrong? Every line matters. Pull all three bureaus — Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion — and review each one carefully. Depending on your loan scenario, we may also be able to use a blended score approach. Ask us about it during your consultation.

- [ ] **Dispute errors immediately**

  Wrong balance? Paid account still showing open? Account that isn't yours? Dispute directly with each bureau online. Disputes typically resolve within 30 days — start now.

- [ ] **Do NOT open new accounts**

  Every credit application triggers a hard inquiry and can drop your score 5–10 points. No new cards, no store credit, no auto loans — nothing until after closing.

- [ ] **Do NOT close old accounts**

  Credit age and utilization matter. Closing your oldest card hurts your score even if you don't use it. Leave existing accounts open and keep balances at 30% utilization or below.

- [ ] **Record your score from each bureau**

  The three scores are rarely identical. Mortgage lenders use the middle score (not the average). One bureau with a bad data point can change your qualifying loan type.

★ MINIMUM CREDIT SCORE REQUIREMENTS BY LOAN TYPE

VA Loan: No VA-set minimum — most lenders require 580–620+. Unfiltered Keys will discuss your specific options.

FHA Loan: 580+ for 3.5% down / 500–579 for 10% down

USDA Loan: 640+ (most lenders) — check eligible areas in Copperas Cove / Coryell County

Conventional: 620+ minimum / 740+ for the best available interest rates

Record your scores here: Equifax: _____ Experian: _____ TransUnion: _____

WEEK 2 Days 8–14

Income & Debt Audit

- [ ] **Calculate your gross monthly income**

  This is before taxes — the number on your pay stub before deductions. Salary: annual ÷ 12. Hourly: rate × avg hours/week × 52 ÷ 12. Include all verified, documentable income.

- [ ] **List every minimum monthly debt payment**

  Car loans, student loans, credit card minimums, personal loans, child support, alimony. Also include any Buy Now, Pay Later (BNPL) accounts — Affirm, Afterpay, Klarna, Sezzle, PayPal Pay Later, Shopify Pay, and similar. These are point-of-sale loans and count against your DTI just like any other installment debt. Do NOT include utilities, subscriptions, groceries, or insurance — those are not counted in DTI.

- [ ] **Calculate your Debt-to-Income ratio (DTI)**

  Formula: Total Monthly Debts ÷ Gross Monthly Income × 100 = DTI%. Example: $1,200 debts ÷ $5,000 income = 24% DTI. Use the worksheet on pages 6–7.

- [ ] **Understand your max qualifying payment**

  Your new housing payment (P + I + taxes + insurance = PITI) is added to your existing debts. Most loan types want the combined total below 41–45% of gross monthly income.

WEEK 3 Days 15–21

Bank Statements & Paper Trail

- [ ] **60 days of statements for ALL bank accounts**

  Pull the last two months of statements for every account you own — checking, savings, investment, retirement, all of it. Every page, even the ones that say "this page intentionally left blank." Your lender needs to see where your down payment money is sitting and that you will have funds left over after closing.

- [ ] **Flag any large deposits now — before your lender sees them**

  Underwriters are required to source every deposit that is not a regular paycheck. If it cannot be documented, it cannot be used. Before your pre-approval, make a list of any transfers, gifts, side income, or lump-sum deposits that have hit your accounts in the last 60 days. Your broker can help you document them correctly — getting ahead of this is far easier than explaining it under deadline.

- [ ] **Gift funds? Start the gift letter process**

  If a family member is helping with your down payment or closing costs, that is allowed — but it has to be documented properly. The person giving the money will need to sign a simple letter confirming it is a gift, not a loan they expect back. They will also need to show where the money came from. Start this conversation early so there are no scrambles when the file goes to underwriting.

- [ ] **Know your reserve requirement**

  A reserve is money left in your bank account after you have paid everything to close — your down payment, closing costs, all of it. Lenders want to see that you are not wiped out the day you get your keys. Most loan types want to see at least 2–3 months of your future housing payment sitting in your account as a cushion. The more reserves you have, the stronger your file looks to an underwriter — it signals you can handle the mortgage even if something unexpected comes up. VA loans typically do not require reserves, but having them still works in your favor.

WEEK 4 Days 22–30

Assemble Your Document Package

Gather these before your first lender call. Missing documents are the #1 reason pre-approvals get delayed.

DOCUMENT CHECKLIST — Gather before pre-approval

- ☐ **W-2s**
  2 most recent years — both borrowers
- ☐ **Tax Returns**
  2 years, all pages including schedules
- ☐ **Pay Stubs**
  Most recent 30 days
- ☐ **Bank Statements**
  60 days, all accounts, all pages
- ☐ **Photo ID**
  Driver's license or passport
- ☐ **Social Security Card**
  Or proof of SSN
- ☐ **Self-Employed?**
  2 years business + personal tax returns, YTD P&L
- ☐ **VA Borrowers:**
  DD-214 (discharge) or Statement of Service if active duty
- ☐ **VA Certificate of Eligibility:**
  Pull at VA.gov — takes 10 minutes
- ☐ **Divorced?**
  Decree if paying or receiving alimony / child support
- ☐ **Rental Income?**
  Lease agreements + 2 years Schedule E from taxes
- ☐ **Bankruptcy / Foreclosure:**
  Discharge papers + explanation letter

✓ END OF PHASE 1 CHECKPOINT

You should now have: clean credit report (or active disputes filed), DTI calculated, 60 days of bank statements, full document package assembled, and your VA COE if applicable. Next: complete the Budget Worksheet, then move to Phase 2.

Your Real Numbers Budget Worksheet

Fill in your actual numbers below. This is the same math your lender runs. Complete this before your first call with a broker.

A Monthly Gross Income (before taxes)

Gross Monthly Income — Borrower 1	$
Gross Monthly Income — Borrower 2 (if applicable)	$
Other Verified Income (rental, child support, retirement, pension, etc.)	$
TOTAL GROSS MONTHLY INCOME (A1 + A2 + A3)	**$**

B Current Monthly Debt Payments (minimum payments only)

Include: car loans, student loans, credit cards, personal loans, child support, alimony.
Do NOT include: rent, utilities, subscriptions, groceries, phone, or insurance.

Car payment(s)	$
Student loans	$
Credit card minimum payments (total all cards)	$
Personal loans / Buy-Now-Pay-Later / other installment debt	$
Child support or alimony (court-ordered amounts only)	$
TOTAL MONTHLY DEBTS (add all B fields)	**$**

C Debt-to-Income Ratio (DTI)

Formula: Total Monthly Debts (B) ÷ Total Gross Monthly Income (A) × 100 = Your DTI%

My DTI: _____ ÷ _____ × 100 = _____ %

Target DTI: **VA < 41%** **FHA < 43%** **USDA < 41%** **Conventional < 45%**

These are general guidelines — approval is possible with higher DTI depending on your loan type, credit profile, and compensating factors. Ask us.

D Estimated Maximum Monthly Housing Payment

Step 1: Total Gross Income (A) × 0.41 = _____

Step 2: Subtract Total Monthly Debts (B) = _____ **= Estimated Max Monthly Payment (PITI)**

PITI = Principal + Interest + Property Taxes + Homeowners Insurance. Actual qualification depends on loan type, current rate, and full underwriting review.

Understanding Texas Property Taxes

Property taxes in Texas are not a footnote — they are a core part of your monthly housing payment and directly affect what you qualify for. Many buyers are surprised by the bill. This section gives you the full picture before you apply.

How Your Property Tax Bill Is Calculated

Your annual property tax is calculated by multiplying the county's assessed value of your home by the combined tax rate for your taxing jurisdictions (county, city, school district, and any special districts). That annual amount is divided by 12 and added to your monthly mortgage payment — this is the "T" in PITI.

STEP 1

Assessed Value

County appraisal district estimates your home's market value each year

STEP 2

x Tax Rate

Combined rate from all taxing jurisdictions (county + city + school)

STEP 3

= Annual Tax

Divide by 12 to get your monthly escrow amount added to your payment

EXAMPLE CALCULATION

Home price: $280,000 · Assessed value: $280,000 · Combined tax rate: 2.10%

$280,000 × 0.0210 = $5,880 per year ÷ 12 = $490 per month added to your payment.

At a 2.40% rate that same home costs $672/month in taxes. The rate difference on one home is $182/month — $2,184/year. This is why knowing your county's rate before you shop matters.

Improved vs. Unimproved Property

Your tax bill is based on the appraised value of both the land and any structure on it. This distinction matters most for new construction buyers and anyone buying on recently developed land.

Unimproved Land

Vacant lot — no structure built yet

Taxed on land value only. If you buy a lot or a home is under construction, the county appraises it as unimproved and the bill is lower. Once the structure is completed and the county reassesses, the full tax bill applies.

Improved Property

Land + completed structure (your home)

Taxed on land value plus the completed home. This is what you will pay once you close on a finished property. The county appraises both the lot and the structure, and your annual bill reflects both values.

★ NEW CONSTRUCTION BUYERS — READ THIS

If you are buying a new build, your first year tax bill may be based on the unimproved (lot only) value because the home was not complete on January 1st of that tax year. Your lender will estimate taxes at the full improved value for escrow purposes — correct long-term — but the first year actual bill may be lower. Do not budget around the lower number. Once the county reassesses, your escrow adjusts and the full bill applies. Plan for the improved rate from day one.

Texas Rates, Exemptions & Homeowners Insurance

E Texas Property Tax Rates by Market

County / Market Area	Typical Annual Rate Range	Notes
Bell County Killeen, Temple, Belton, Harker Heights	**1.85% – 2.20%**	VA / military market
Williamson County Round Rock, Georgetown, Cedar Park, Leander	**2.00% – 2.40%**	High-growth, new construction
Coryell County Copperas Cove, Gatesville, Kempner	**1.60% – 1.95%**	USDA-eligible areas
Travis County Austin metro edge, Pflugerville, Manor	**1.90% – 2.35%**	Higher cost; verify budget
Dallas / Collin / Denton Counties Dallas, Fort Worth, Plano, Frisco, McKinney, Allen, Garland	**2.10% – 2.60%**	DFW — confirm city rate
Bexar County San Antonio, Leon Valley, Converse, Schertz	**2.00% – 2.45%**	Rates vary by area
Harris / Fort Bend / Montgomery Counties Houston, Sugar Land, Katy, The Woodlands, Pearland	**2.00% – 2.50%**	MUD districts can add cost
El Paso County El Paso, Socorro, Horizon City	**1.70% – 2.10%**	Lower than most TX metros

Target home price: $ _____ × rate from above = Annual taxes: $ _____

Monthly property tax estimate (annual ÷ 12): $ _____ *← add this to your PITI estimate on page 6*

TEXAS PROPERTY TAX EXEMPTIONS — FILE AFTER CLOSING

HOMESTEAD EXEMPTION: Reduces taxable value by $100,000 (2023 law). File with your county appraisal district in the same year you close.

VA DISABILITY EXEMPTION: A 100% disability rating can mean a full property tax exemption on your Texas primary residence. Partial ratings receive a scaled reduction. Apply with your VA award letter at your county appraisal district.

OVER-65 EXEMPTION: Additional $10,000 exemption plus a school tax freeze — the school portion of your bill cannot increase as long as you own the home. File in the year you turn 65.

Homeowners Insurance — The "I" in PITI

Lenders require homeowners insurance before closing — no exceptions. It protects the property they are lending against. Your annual premium is divided by 12 and added to your monthly escrow payment alongside your taxes.

Down Payment & Closing Cost Tracker

F Down Payment & Closing Cost Tracker

Use this section to track exactly how much cash you need at closing and whether your savings are on track. Many buyers underestimate closing costs — budget 2–4% of the purchase price on top of your down payment.

Target home price	$
Down payment amount (VA/USDA: 0% · FHA: 3.5% · Conventional: 3–20%)	$
Estimated closing costs (typically 2–4% in Texas — see closing cost breakdown in Phase 3)	$
Total cash needed at closing (down payment + closing costs)	$
Current savings available for home purchase	$
Monthly savings contribution toward home purchase	$

Savings gap (Total needed minus current savings): $ _____

Estimated months to reach savings goal (gap ÷ monthly contribution):
_____ months → target ready date: _____

VA LOAN DOWN PAYMENT NOTE: VA loans allow 0% down for eligible borrowers with full entitlement. However, you still need cash for closing costs (or negotiate seller concessions) and ideally 2–3 months of reserves after closing. The funding fee (1.25%–3.3%) can be rolled into the loan. If you have a service-connected disability rating, the funding fee is waived entirely.

My Tax, Insurance & Down Payment Notes

County I am buying in:

Estimated annual property tax:

Monthly tax estimate (escrow):

Is the property improved or unimproved?

Homestead exemption filed (after closing):

VA disability exemption applies?

Homeowners insurance quote:

Flood insurance required?

Down payment source:

Gift funds involved? (if yes, start letter process)

Closing cost estimate from broker:

Target closing date:

Get Pre-Approved & Get Smart

Phase 2 is where your preparation pays off. You're ready to talk to a broker, understand your loan options, and start shopping with real numbers — not guesses.

Step 1 — Work With a Broker, Not Just a Bank

	Mortgage Broker	Bank or Credit Union
Access to lenders	Shops 20+ wholesale lenders for your file	Offers only their own products
Rate shopping	Compares rates across lenders on your behalf	One rate — take it or leave it
VA expertise	Often specializes; knows VA nuances well	May or may not have VA experience
If declined	Can pivot to a different lender quickly	Decline = start over elsewhere

Step 2 — Get Pre-Approved (Not Just Pre-Qualified)

✕ Pre-Qualification

Based on self-reported numbers with no verification, no credit pull, and no document review. Sellers and agents give it little weight. It's a rough estimate — not a commitment.

✓ Pre-Approval

Credit pulled. Income and assets verified. Underwriting reviewed your full document package. Sellers take this seriously. This is the letter you want before you make an offer.

Step 3 — Know Your Loan Options

VA LOAN

For active duty, veterans, and eligible surviving spouses. 0% down · No PMI ever · Funding fee 1.25–3.3% (waived with VA disability rating). Must have a Certificate of Eligibility (COE). Always explore VA first if you qualify.

FHA LOAN

3.5% down with 580+ credit / 10% down with 500–579. MIP (mortgage insurance) required for life of loan if under 10% down. More lenient DTI guidelines. Good option when rebuilding credit or savings are limited.

USDA LOAN

0% down for eligible rural and suburban areas — Copperas Cove / Coryell County often qualifies. Income limits apply (typically 115% of area median). Annual guarantee fee 0.35%. Check the USDA eligibility map before assuming you qualify.

CONVENTIONAL

3–5% down with 620+ credit. Best pricing at 740+ credit. PMI required under 20% down (but removable at 80% LTV). HomeReady and Home Possible programs offer 3% down with income limits.

★ TEXAS-SPECIFIC THINGS YOUR OUT-OF-STATE FRIENDS DON'T KNOW

Option Period: Texas contracts include a separate option period (typically 5–10 days, $50–$500 fee). This buys you the right to back out for ANY reason. Use it for inspection.

Community Property State: If married, both spouses may need to sign documents even if only one is on the loan.

Homestead Exemption: File with your county appraisal district after closing. Reduces taxable value by $100,000 (2023 law). File the year you close.

Make Your Move

You have a pre-approval letter and you know your budget. Now you're shopping for real. Phase 3 is about executing correctly — from offer to keys — without making mistakes that derail deals at the finish line.

Making an Offer in Texas

- ☐ **Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)**

  Typically $500–$2,000 for most Texas price ranges. Held in escrow and credited toward closing costs or down payment at closing. Higher EMD signals a serious buyer.

- ☐ **Option Fee (separate from earnest money)**

  A small negotiated fee ($50–$500+) paid directly to the seller. This buys you the option period — your window to inspect and cancel for any reason. It is typically non-refundable.

- ☐ **Option Period (Texas-specific right)**

  Typically 5–10 days. During this window you can cancel for any reason and keep your earnest money. Use it for inspection. Do not waive it to look competitive — it protects you.

- ☐ **Third-Party Financing Addendum**

  This Texas-specific addendum protects you if your loan is denied for the reasons specified. You can back out and recover your earnest money if financing falls through.

Offer-to-Closing Timeline (30-day close estimate)

Timeline	Milestone	Action / Note
Days 1–3	**Option Period Begins**	Schedule inspection immediately — don't wait.
Days 1–5	**Loan File Submitted**	Broker submits your complete package to underwriting.
Days 3–7	**Home Inspection**	Hire your own inspector. Attend in person if possible.
Days 7–14	**Appraisal Ordered**	Lender orders it. You pay. Lender reviews the result.
Days 10–21	**Underwriting Review**	May issue "conditions." Respond within hours, not days.
Days 14–25	**Appraisal Result**	If low: negotiate price, pay the gap, or invoke addendum.
Days 25–28	**Clear to Close (CTC)**	Final underwriting approval. The green light.
Day 27	**Closing Disclosure**	Received 3 business days before closing. Review every line.
Day 29	**Final Walkthrough**	24 hours before closing. Verify condition and repairs.
Day 30	**CLOSING DAY ★**	Sign docs. Wire transfer or cashier's check. Get keys.

Typical Texas Closing Costs (estimate — Loan Estimate will be exact)

Cost Item	Typical Amount	Notes
Appraisal	**$500–$750**	Paid upfront or at closing
Title Insurance — Owner's Policy	**~0.5–0.8% of price**	One-time in Texas. Protects you.
Title Insurance — Lender's Policy	**~0.4–0.6% of price**	Protects lender. Required.
Survey	**$400–$650**	Required by most lenders in Texas
Escrow / Closing Fee	**$400–$800**	Paid to title company
Prepaid Interest	**Varies by close date**	Interest from closing date to month end
Initial Escrow Impound	**2–3 months taxes + insurance**	Funds your escrow account
Lender Origination	**0–1% of loan amount**	Varies — brokers often lower than retail
Recording Fees	**$50–$150**	County recording of deed and deed of trust

The DO NOT List — Before & During Your Purchase

More deals fall apart in the 30–60 days between offer acceptance and closing than at any other point in the process. The reason is almost always the buyer. Read this twice.

✕ DO NOT open new credit accounts

No new credit cards, auto loans, personal loans, or buy-now-pay-later — not even for furniture. Hard inquiries and new debt can change your DTI and score overnight. Wait until after closing.

✕ DO NOT make large, unexplained deposits

Any deposit that is not a regular paycheck requires documentation. If you're moving money or depositing cash, tell your broker before it happens — not after underwriting flags it.

✕ DO NOT change jobs without telling your broker immediately

Lenders verify employment the day before closing. Changing jobs — even for higher pay — can reset your qualifying timeline. Communicate any job change to your broker the moment it happens.

✕ DO NOT co-sign on anyone else's loan

Co-signing adds that monthly payment to your DTI even if you're not the one making it. This is a quiet deal-killer that surprises borrowers every week.

✕ DO NOT make large purchases on credit

New furniture, appliances, electronics, or a car — anything that shows up as new debt on your next credit pull can change what you qualify for. Buy after closing, with cash if possible.

✕ DO NOT miss any existing bill payments

Late payments during the mortgage process are extremely damaging. Set up autopay for minimums on every account and do not touch those funds until after you have closed.

✕ DO NOT move large amounts of money between accounts without documentation

Bank-to-bank transfers are fine — but underwriters will ask for statements from both accounts (sending and receiving). Keep a clean paper trail and tell your broker about any large moves.

✕ DO NOT assume the deal is done until you have keys in hand

Final underwriting review, last-minute title issues, and lien discoveries can surface late. Stay engaged, respond to every request within hours, and don't start hiring movers until the deed has recorded.

Master Checklist + Next Steps

PHASE 1 — Days 1–30

- [ ] Pull credit reports from all 3 bureaus
- [ ] Dispute any errors with the bureau directly
- [ ] Calculate gross monthly income
- [ ] List all minimum monthly debt payments
- [ ] Calculate DTI using the worksheet
- [ ] Pull 60 days of bank statements (all accounts)
- [ ] Flag and document any large deposits
- [ ] Gather 2 years of W-2s and tax returns
- [ ] Gather 30 days of pay stubs
- [ ] VA borrowers: pull Certificate of Eligibility
- [ ] Stop all new credit applications immediately

PHASE 2 — Days 31–60

- [ ] Contact Unfiltered Keys for initial consultation
- [ ] Select loan type with your broker
- [ ] Submit full document package for pre-approval
- [ ] Receive and review pre-approval letter
- [ ] Set search criteria with a buyer's agent
- [ ] Research neighborhoods and school districts
- [ ] Tour homes within your pre-approved budget
- [ ] Learn Texas option period and earnest money norms

PHASE 3 — Days 61–90

- [ ] Submit offer with pre-approval letter attached
- [ ] Pay earnest money and option fee on time
- [ ] Schedule inspection within option period
- [ ] Review inspection report — negotiate repairs
- [ ] Respond to all underwriting conditions promptly
- [ ] Compare Loan Estimate to Closing Disclosure
- [ ] Wire funds or get cashier's check for closing
- [ ] Complete final walkthrough 24 hrs before closing
- [ ] Bring valid ID and all remaining docs to table
- [ ] ★ **CLOSE — file homestead exemption after**

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Available when you are.

My Notes

Target move date: _____

Target price range: _____

Loan type selected: _____

Pre-approval letter date: _____

Credit score (from worksheet): _____

My DTI (from worksheet): _____

Max monthly payment: _____

Cash ready for closing: _____

Inspection contact: _____

Broker contact: _____

Title company: _____

Closing date (target): _____

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"Structured Mortgage Strategy."

Helping Texas buyers get to the closing table ready, informed, and confident.

SERVING ALL OF TEXAS

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Temple · Round Rock · Georgetown · Waco · Copperas Cove · and beyond

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